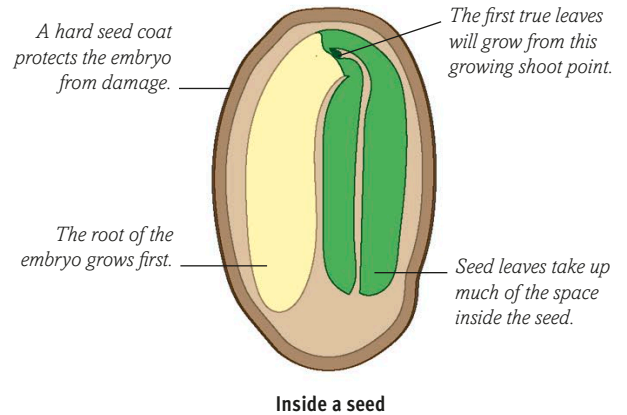


Seed leaves ➤ The first leaf, or pair of leaves, in a flowering plant often looks very different to the true leaves the seedling will grow later. This is because the seed leaves were part of the embryo that lived inside the seed.



Inside a seed

A seed is a perfectly packaged baby plant, called an embryo, protected by a hard outer coat. The embryo has a root and a shoot, and the first true leaves. It also has a food store for the embryo in “seed leaves.”



One leaf or two?

There are two main types of flowering plants—monocots and dicots—named for the number of seed leaves they have. Monocot seeds contain one seed leaf, while dicot seeds have two.

Two broad seed leaves grow out of a dicot seed.



Corn seed (monocot)



Germinating monocot seed



Bean (dicot)



Germinating dicot seed

Early germination

Sometimes seeds germinate before they have parted from their parent plant. This early germination may take the form of shoots growing on the outside of a fruit, as on this strawberry. In other fruits, shoots may even burst through the fruit wall from the seeds held inside.

